three and two years old, respectively – as good an age as any, it seems, to march into their first conquest. Only Daniyal, still an infant, was left behind: he was born in Ajmer to an unnamed mother during the march to Gujarat, and left in the care of Harkha Bai's mother, the queen of Amber. Akbar's own tent, meanwhile, was pitched much closer to the action: cannonballs often landed near it, says Abul Fazl. But what was a little exploding ammunition to the padishah's brave heart?

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Akbar's strength and stamina were reaching epic proportions. Strength, stamina – and courage, their alloy – were, of course, the building blocks of a man's reputation in this age; even more so in the court of a conquering monarch. During the siege of Surat, for example, one of Akbar's commanders was wounded in a reckless attack he insisted on making because he had missed Sarnal, that 'manhood-testing place'.[33]

Stories of valour – and attempted valour, usually accompanied by drink – abound in the chronicles. Once, for example, 200 of Humayun's soldiers had charged upon 4000 enemy troops, no less, in a drunken frenzy – and managed to scare them away. Another time, a party of Humayun's clerks and librarians were celebrating his conquest of Champaner when they were inspired by the *Zafarnama*, Timur's biography, recalled through a thick haze of alcohol, to march upon the Deccan then and there.

After Surat fell – it took a little over six weeks – Akbar and his men were enjoying a similar symposium, it seems, regaling each other with tales of martial daring. The talk turned to which of the clans in the imperial army was most brave. Akbar was spoilt for choice in this regard. If the Chagatai descendants of Chinghis Khan were not to be sneezed at, nor were Indian Muslim warriors like the Sayyids of Barha, who would help Akbar rule Gujarat and be described, one day, as the 'bulwark'[34] of his empire. And, of course, there were the Rajputs.

The Rajput's sense of honour as derived from courage in combat held great appeal for the Central Asian warriors with whom they battled and mingled; particularly the Central Asian warrior who was now their emperor. Of one particular Rajput clan in Gujarat, Abul Fazl writes admiringly that they would dismount from their horses mid-battle, lest the horse – or worse,